

Howrah EXPRESS

By Damayanti Datta

Ask the boys to cool it. Don't lose your head. Move politically," she barks into the cellphone. Hair pulled back, the end of a *doore* Tangail sari gathered up in *bhadramahila* combat mode, eyes scanning faces in quick X-ray glances, she marches into her Parliamentary den at the speed of a hi-tech express. Her office chugs into action; the lounging crowd snaps to life; MPs hurriedly get off their cellphones; outsiders jostle for favour. She scolds a persistent nagger: "I told you I'll look into it. I have to keep in mind one crore eight lakh passengers plying on 17,997 trains everyday, too. Didi can be good but Didi can be tough. Didi says no when she means no."

And Mamata Banerjee has been saying "no" for a long time. Driven by riveting rhetoric, powered by unforgettable antics, laughed at by rivals, but relentlessly, consistently—a rebel. She started out by saying "no" to Jayaprakash Narayan by dancing atop his car bonnet as a young Congress worker. Thirty-five years later, she is still saying "no". It's a different brand of politics—intimate and capricious—that has taken Didi, time and again, to the verge of great success or great loss. Is she moving up that reckless road again?

Right now, the 54-year-old Union minister for Railways, is saying "no" to the new evolving rules for seizing land in India. "We are against forcible acquisition of land," she says. It's not just her. The Land Acquisition (Amendment) Bill, 2007,

discussed by the Union Cabinet on July 23, has raised serious concerns about fair compensation, valuation and definition of 'public purpose' among many. But the Trinamool supremo has pipped all to the post and emerged as the voice of protest.

Expect the unexpected. That has always been the key to her long and storied romance with politics. As the simple, artless Didi next-door she can touch your soul, yet try your patience with repeated threats of resignation; she can paralyse your city with arbitrary demands, yet sing patriotic numbers on reality TV; she can exude raw energy in her fury, yet be the rare VIP to help accident victims; she can reduce her parliamentary colleagues to tears by throwing things at them, yet spend 21 harrowing days in Singur without bathing facilities.

It's a style that civil society finds difficult to decode. "Political theory hasn't matured enough in our country to explain leaders like Mamata or Mayawati," says political psychologist, Ashis Nandy. The new band of leaders know how to engage in hard-edged political tactics, mobilise, campaign and form coalitions effectively, empower a very large section of the

electorate. "But their politics often appear irrational because they are embedded in local rationalities," he adds.

But the calendar seems to have turned a new page. Analysts are peering into crystal balls: "her personality is changing", say some; "her engagement with land politics is serious", add others; "she is emerging as a visions person", claim yet others. If truth be told, it took decades for genteel Kolkata to accept Banerjee as a social equal—though it did, in time. The crumpled sari, dishevelled hair, customary chappals may symbolise high-pitched street politics, but do not conform to the matrix of *bhalo meye*—a sweet, sensitive and accomplished girl. Banerjee did play to the gallery—singing Rabindra sangeet to a harmonium, hair in a braid—but she always cut a surprise figure on the periphery of the city's social snobbery. "It's only as Didi, an elder sister, that Mamata finally found her true niche," says linguist Subhadra Kumar Sen of Kolkata. "That Bangla epithet, combining a sense of affection, authority and protection, captures the qualities many thought they liked in her."

A personality in evolution? Browse through bookstores in Kolkata, you will come up with 26 titles written by, well, Banerjee. Catch her on Bangla TV channels. Didi is spewing Tagore. In fact, an incorrect crack on Tagore a few days back had the ever-snobbish CPI(M) fuming in public ("Is it possible to prosper under a leader who goes wrong on Tagore?"). "Do you read Garcia Marquez, Buddhadeb Bhattacharjee's favourite author?" journalists say as they discuss books with her these days. "I just love Tagore," she always says. Her new penchant for acquiring intellectualism, that Bengali fetish, shows how serious she is about winning hearts and minds in the state.

A mistress of catchy slogans, she is trying to roll a blue print of development as well. In case you thought she is not progressive enough, post-Singur and Nandigram, she calls it, "*Hashi-Khushi*", where agriculture is *hashi* and industry *khushi*—the twin pillars of *joie de vivre*. "She has ma-

“They talk about your vision when you're successful. Slip up, they call you a loser.”

MAMATA BANERJEE